

THE NINE-COUNT — WOMEN'S RANK ADORNMENT

(Era of Solis — the Kingdom of Aicruae, prior to its absorption into the Solisian Empire)

In Aicruae a woman's rank is worn on her left wrist and read at a glance. The left arm is the rank arm, governed by law; the right arm is her own, for heirlooms, gifts, and whatever she pleases. The count runs on the same nines the court already bows to — nine rungs in the class ladder, nine prostrations owed to the crown — so the Queen's wrist carries the full nine, and every woman beneath her carries fewer.

THE LADDER (count and material are legal ceilings, not requirements):

1. Nine, deep gold — the Queen alone. No other wrist in the kingdom may hold nine.
2. Eight, deep gold — princesses and the wives of heirs to the throne.
3. Seven, gilt — royal consorts and concubines at their full ceiling (see The Consort Lane).
4. Six, gold — Des women (extended royal blood).
5. Five, gold — duchesses.
6. Four, silver — Ashanti wives.
7. Three, bronze — the wives of high government officials (Piesto). Wealthy merchant wives may wear up to three by purchased crown license, renewed yearly.
8. Two, copper or horn — the wives of knights and traders.
9. One, cord or lacquered wood — common women.

Because the counts are ceilings, wearing fewer is never a crime, and an underdressed wrist speaks its own language: a duchess wearing two of her five is in mourning or making a point; a farmwife's single cord is simply her life. Wearing more than your station allows is a moderate crime under the Code of Esa — fines, whipping, or the cangue, with branding for

repeat offenders.

THE CONSORT LANE:

Consorts and concubines of the royal family wear gilt — silver washed in gold. Beside true royal gold it passes at a distance and fails up close, which is the point: adjacent to royalty, legally never it. And gilt wears through.

Within the palace the inner court runs on capped grades: one consort of the First Grade, two of the Second, four of the Third, six of the Fourth, and an open number of entrants beneath them. Grade sets how many of her seven a consort has actually been conferred. An entrant wears three. Every promotion is a public ceremony in which the ruler adds one bangle to her wrist, and the whole court counts. A First Grade consort at her full seven stands exactly one bangle short of a princess, and everyone can see the distance. Sons are counted in gilt; a barren year is counted too.

OWNERSHIP — THE COLD CLAUSE:

A wife owns her bangles. A consort borrows hers. Consort regalia is crown property, reclaimed at dismissal or death. Honorable removal slides a bangle off whole; disgrace cuts it off with shears. A stripping is performed before the court, one bangle at a time.

ENFORCEMENT & THE BLACK MARKET:

Counterfeit gilt and unlicensed bronze move through the UIB alongside the forged noble patents they already sell, with Basar Tari as the workshop. Crown licenses for merchant wives are a modest but reliable source of royal revenue, and license fraud is treated as forgery, not vanity.

SOUND:

Bangles are loud. Rank announces itself down a corridor before a woman turns the corner, and a muffled wrist is suspicious by definition — servants, guards, and rivals all know what a wrapped arm means.

[TBD] Dowager queens — does she keep the nine, or trade deep gold for a mourning form?

[TBD] Widows and the rank arm — resolve under Funeral Customs.

[TBD] In-world name for the rank bangles themselves.

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[TBD] Widows and the rank arm — resolve under Funeral Customs.

MARRIAGE CUSTOMS — THE ANTLER SUIT

(Era of Solis — the Kingdom of Aicruae, prior to its absorption into the Solisian Empire)

In Aicruae a man proposes marriage with an antler, and the antler is the offer. Its points are counted, its origin is told aloud, and both are judged. The custom has one absolute rule underneath all its ceremony: no antler, no wife. A consort is, by definition, a woman for whom no antler was ever brought. Her gilt kess and her missing antler are the same sentence written twice, and "there's no antler on her wall" is the polite-vicious way of saying what she is.

THE TINE LADDER:

The count of points is matched against the standing of her family. Roe heads — six points at their best — carry the suits of common folk. Red deer carry the ranked. Nine tines is the threshold for courting into the nobility, the same nine the kingdom counts everywhere else. A full Royal head, twelve points with all his rights and a three-point crown on top, is owed for ducal daughters; fourteen and above belongs to suits for the blood royal. The crown of a true high head forms a cup, and the rite is sealed by pouring wine into the bone and both families drinking from it.

Offering under her tine is a formal insult, and her family may demand restitution or a second head in apology. Offering over her tine is presumption: it either obligates her family beyond their intent or shames them as beggars reaching upward. Daughters are compared in points, at court and at kitchen tables, and everyone pretends this is not what is happening.

THE STATED HEAD:

Before any suit begins, her uncles or family representatives state the expected head — the count and quality her family will accept. Parents do not conduct this themselves. The stated head is not a secret; it travels, and a woman's stated head is the closest thing Aicruae has to a posted worth.

THE NAMING:

The suitor must take or find the head himself, unaided. When it is presented, it is named before her family: where it came from, how it was got, by blood or by finding, on whose land, witnessed by whom. The naming is spoken in the old way, and an accepted head enters the family's songs with its story attached. Place outranks size — a lean nine-tine head off the northern mountains carries more honor than a fat park stag of equal count, and legend keeps an empty seat above every ladder for a head touched by the Mystic Isles, which no sane man hunts and no living family displays.

A bought head is the deep disgrace. The UIB moves antlers with forged provenances out of Basar Tari all the same, and a man caught presenting one loses the betrothal, and his name, in the same afternoon. Because provenance rests on honor and witnesses, the custom runs, quietly, on lies waiting to surface.

THE ANTLER'S LIFE:

An accepted head hangs in her father's hall from acceptance until the wedding, then moves above the couple's own hearth, where it stays for life. A head that never leaves her father's wall is a broken betrothal, and the whole district can see it. Refusal has its

own grammar: an antler returned whole is a courteous no, and the suit may be remade with a greater head; an antler returned broken means never, and families have bled over less.

Among royalty the form is observed and the treaty is real. Whether a king's son truly took his own head is a thing courts make a point of not asking.

[TBD] In-world name for the custom and for the presented head itself.

[TBD] The antler at widowhood, divorce, or annulment — resolve alongside Funeral Customs.

[TBD] Which of the twelve gods, if any, claims the stag — check against the Religion doc before canonizing any divine tie.

MARRIAGE CUSTOMS — THE LIPEN (THE ANTLER SUIT)

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In Aicruae a man proposes marriage with an antler, and the antler is the offer. Rite and head share one name: lipen — one lipen, many lipen, the word does not change. In the oldest tellings the suit was sealed with paired hides rather than heads; the antler replaced the skin somewhere before the records begin, which in Aicruae means before Hailour I burned them, and the word never changed. Its points are counted, its origin is told aloud, and both are judged. The custom has one absolute rule underneath all its ceremony: no lipen, no wife. A consort is, by definition, a woman for whom no lipen was ever brought. Her guilt and her missing lipen are the same sentence written twice, and "there's no antler on her wall" is the polite-vicious way of saying what she is.

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[TBD] The lipen at widowhood, divorce, or annulment — resolve alongside Funeral Customs.

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MARRIAGE CUSTOMS — THE ORDER OF THE SUIT, THE IRON CHEST, AND THE SEVEN COUNTS

(Era of Solis — the Kingdom of Aicruae, prior to its absorption into the Solisian Empire)

THE ORDER OF THE SUIT:

A proper Aicruaeen marriage moves through six steps, and skipping any of them is what separates a wife from everything less.

1. THE HIDE. The suit opens with a dressed hide brought to her family's door — the fossil of the oldest lipen, from the days when skins sealed betrothals. A hide may be declined without insult; it is the only step in the whole order that can be.
2. THE STATED HEAD. Her uncles state the expected lipen. (See: The Lipen.)
3. THE FAITH-SETTING. Before any hunt, the families settle before priests whose practice the household will follow — his, or hers in an uxorilocal match — and pay the temple for the ruling. Mixed suits between Leneyez and Barqeten houses die at this step more often than at any other, before anyone has even brought bone.
4. THE LIPEN AND ITS NAMING. (See: The Lipen.)
5. THE LISTING. His family's betrothal gifts, itemized in a letter and read aloud at her door. The gifts go to her family — and stay there in honor only if untouched. A family that spends the Listing on its own debts is said to have sold their daughter, and the words follow the whole house.
6. THE ANSWER. Her dowry, carried to his house in open procession, because display is the point. What is carried is counted, by everyone watching.

At the wedding, alongside the Tal-Sel, comes the re-wristing. A wife wears her husband's station, so her father's-rank kess are removed and her married count is put on, before

witnesses. A girl marrying upward gains gold in front of the whole district. A duchess's daughter marrying a knight has three kess taken off her arm while everyone watches it grow lighter. The ladder does the cruelty; the ceremony only makes it visible.

THE IRON CHEST:

The dowry is hers. Not the household's, not her husband's — hers, for life, untouchable by him in law, and it descends to her children alone. Her kess ride at the top of it. The chest is inventoried publicly in the Answer, so the district knows what she came with, and it is the third leg of what makes a wife a wife: she owns her kess, she has a lipen on the wall, she came with a chest. A consort has none of the three. The cost of the custom is borne by fathers: dowries climb, houses heavy with daughters bleed, and the birth of a third girl is condoled like a poor harvest.

THE COMPANIONS:

Among the ranked houses, a chest may include women. Companions — chosen by her family, listed in the Answer like the rest of it — who serve her in her marriage and may, in the great houses, be elevated to her husband's consorts. It is exactly as cold as it sounds, and it is also the wife's armory: those women are hers, loyal upward to her and her family, and a great lady arrives at her marriage with her own faction pre-installed in any future inner court. Half the ladies-in-waiting who make women's spaces into surveillance hubs arrived in somebody's chest.

THE SEVEN COUNTS AND THE THREE WALLS:

A husband may put out a wife on seven counts, spoken before a magistrate: defiance of his parents; no son (a count that cannot be spoken while she is yet of bearing years);

adultery; jealousy; grave sickness; a loose tongue; and theft of the household, for even a wife spends its goods only with leave. Against the counts stand three walls, each of which bars a putting-out outright: she has no natal roof left to return to; she mourned his parents the full term; or he was poor when they wed and is rich now. The walls fall only before adultery or grave sickness. A man who puts out a wife without a true count, or over a standing wall, answers to the Code of Esa — fines and the whip — and her status is restored whether he wants her back or not.

One thing no count and no court can do: a wife can never be made a consort. The lipen cannot be un-brought. You cannot guilt a woman who owns gold.

LAW BELOW, TREATY ABOVE:

Among common folk the counts are law and the magistrate's word ends it; a put-out wife leaves with her chest and her father's count restored to her wrist. Among the ranked houses a marriage is a treaty, and ends like one: the chest returned whole, the lipen carried back to her father's hall, and both houses' allies choosing sides by sundown. A returned lipen between great houses has started feuds that outlived everyone at the wedding. A wife holds no counts of her own — the law gives her no door — so her recourse is her family's weight, the walls, and time.

[TBD] The chest and the lipen at widowhood; widow remarriage — resolve with Funeral Customs.

[TBD] Full wedding-day rite (vows, feast, procession order) — expand in a later pass.

[TBD] Consort contracts — how a consort is formally taken, since she gets no suit. Ties to the legitimacy question (children of the chest-companions vs. children of the wife).

FAMILY STRUCTURE — THE INTERIOR, THE LINE, AND THE ENTERING HUSBAND

(Era of Solis — the Kingdom of Aicruae, prior to its absorption into the Solisian Empire)

THE INTERIOR:

The wife rules the interior. Every consort, companion, and household woman answers to her: she assigns duties, quarters, and proximity, and any elevation of a chest-companion to consort passes formally through her hands, since the woman was hers to begin with. A husband takes new consorts only with the wife's formal assent — and her assent is mandatory theater, because jealousy sits among the Seven Counts, so the law forbids her refusal before she can speak it. Form is power anyway. She controls everything but the fact of it.

When a matter rises past housekeeping — an open altercation between wife and consort, an accusation, anything the interior cannot settle — it goes to the husband, who judges between them. A consort who carries a grievance over the wife's head is making the most dangerous bet available to her: if he sides with her, she has won a battle and declared a war.

Above them all stands the widow-mother. Formal headship passes to sons, but filial duty runs upward, and an adult son owes his mother obedience before the whole watching world — which is how a dowager becomes too powerful to ignore and too dangerous to trust.

THE LINE:

The law recognizes only the wife's children. A consort's child is illegitimate — fed,

clothed, raised under his father's roof, and standing outside the line entirely. What the father's word can do is grant comfort: education, placement, a knighthood bought, an office arranged, gifts from his purse. What it can never touch is the patrimony. Purse, not blood.

And even the purse has limits the law doesn't write. Favoring a consort's children over the wife's is deeply frowned upon everywhere, and among the ranked houses it is worse than frowned upon, because the wife is usually the highest-born woman under the roof — a noble daughter, wed with a stated head and an iron chest. To prefer a lower-born consort's child over hers slights her house, not only her bed, and houses answer slights. The flatterers' word for a favored consort is "the second wife," which insults the wife and endangers the consort in the same breath.

THE TITLES: Every child of the household, of every mother, addresses the wife as Dera — the old word for kin, raised the same way Der became Des, and claiming something more durable than blood: motherhood of the house. The consorts are Ama and Ame, and the difference is one vowel a child learns before learning why — Ama is the consort who bore you; Ame is every other consort under the roof. Concubines — women kept without formal elevation, for the line between consort and concubine is the conferral itself — are addressed as Yena, kin to the word for an aunt, which is the entire arrangement said politely. The system runs on a quiet inversion the wives themselves rarely miss: the woman with all the authority holds the formal title, and the women with none hold the soft ones. And there is exactly one door through which a consort's child can enter the line: the wife herself. A sonless wife may formally adopt a consort's child into her own motherhood, making the child legitimately, legally hers. She holds that door, she alone decides if it opens, and she can open it once. In the great houses, every consort raising a promising boy knows who she is truly raising him for.

THE ENTERING HUSBAND:

In an uxorilocal match the suit runs in reverse: her family brings the hide and the Listing, he arrives with a chest, and no lipen is hung at all — he did not take her; her house took him. His children belong to her line. His standing is marked, and the district knows what a bare wall over a married hearth means: the entering husband and the consort share the same naked wall.

[TBD] Royal succession cross-check — confirm against the History / House Patton canon that the crown follows the same line-law before treating it as absolute for the throne.

[TBD] The lesser title a consort's child uses for his birth mother — name-beat available.

[TBD] Elder and ancestor rites within the family — cross-check the Religion doc before adding any veneration structure here.

THE NINE-COUNT UNDER THE EMPIRE — THE CASCADE, THE TWELVE, AND THE TURN TO RINGS

(Imperial period, Era of Solis)

THE CASCADE: The empire never issued a marking law. It didn't need one. The imperial court adopted the kess grammar because an empire loves legible rank, and what the court wears, the provinces wear a generation later. Within living memory of the unification, women in all five other former kingdoms wore kess whose grandmothers had never heard the word. But only in Aicruae was the count law. Abroad it was fashion — a Ghercin lady's four silver kess meant nothing any magistrate could touch, while an Ashanti wife's four meant everything. Aicruae won the empire's wrists and lost ownership of its own custom, and "they wear our law as jewelry" became a grievance and a boast in the same breath. The

predictable followed: counts inflated abroad, where exceeding was merely vulgar rather than criminal, and year by year the count grew less trustworthy as a read of rank anywhere the Code of Esa didn't run.

THE TWELVE AND THE HIGH MOTHER: The Empress alone wears twelve — not the top of the mortal ladder but a departure from it, the count of the gods on a living wrist. No queen lost her nine; the Empress was simply never in their competition. And she alone among the empire's women is religiously marked: her body painted in gold and silver dye, drawn over with markings of religious protection, the living icon of the Empire's sacred authority — the High Mother. Where the kings of the old kingdoms ruled by law, the imperial center ruled by sanctity, and her painted skin was the argument.

(Era of Minara)

THE MARKINGS SPREAD: By Minara's era the High Mother's paint had cascaded like everything else. Noblewomen wear the gold-and-silver markings at celebrations, drawn alongside their kess — the sacred made seasonal, protection as adornment.

THE TURN TO RINGS: Rings existed under Solis as a trend and nothing more. In Minara's era, with the count debased by a hundred years of imperial fashion and nine bangles being a fortune worn loud on one arm, noblewomen made rings the working signifier of rank — and rank's grammar shifted from arithmetic to iconography. What matters on a ring is the motif: whose sign you have the right to wear. The motifs of Vapaz and his wife Nimlye, the king and queen of the gods, belong solely to the Emperor and the Empress — their custom identifiers — and nobody could be caught dead wearing them. Beneath that, the pantheon is parcelled out as rank-rights. The kess did not vanish; they became regalia, worn with the

markings at high occasions, while the rings carry the everyday law.

[TBD] The full motif-to-rank mapping of the twelve gods — assign once the god-list is in front of us.

[TBD] Crandona's era sits unaddressed between these two: the Tanan Grand Duchy period — what the demotion did to these customs, and the open question of why Aicruae lost its crown while Gherci kept one. Next sub-item.

THE GRAND DUCHESS'S EIGHT:

Reduced from queen, the first lady of Tanan would by rank have fallen to seven — the consorts' count — and read across any hall like somebody's First Consort. The empire spared her that, granting eight in gold by imperial grace, and called it mercy. It was a leash. The ninth kess sat one count away for the whole life of the duchy, and every Grand Duchess wore the empire's favor and the empire's reminder on the same arm.

"TANAN":

The name was Tarmet's, not Aicruae's. Imposed from the imperial seat, it carried no local root and was meant to carry none — a realm renamed by the people who reduced it, the old name unpersoned. The duchy's own people used it because they had to, and never without tasting what it was for. When the name Lajazer rose in Minara's era, the discarding of "Tanan" was the point of it.

[TBD] The old Aicruaeen royal house name — needed to track the deposed line into later eras.

[TBD] Etymology of "Tanan" in the imperial tongue — a name-beat if you want the erasure to

cut in-world, or deliberately rootless if that's the sharper choice.

THE FALL TO TANAN — HOW AICRUAE LOST ITS CROWN

(Era of Crandona)

THE CASE AGAINST AICRUAE:

The demotion was argued from three files, and only one of them was the real reason.

1. THE GRAIN REBELLION. In an imperial crisis, the center raised the grain levy, and Aicruae — the realm that feeds half the world — slow-walked the harvest. It was the breadbasket's one weapon, and using it even once taught the empire something it could not afford to know: that the granary had teeth. This was the crime that mattered in Tarmet. It is not the one they said aloud.
2. THE SALT POISONING. A merchant named Ahindo Yasavic slipped poison into the salt, and more than thirty thousand people died of it, directly and indirectly. Whatever his reasons, the count of the dead became the count against the crown that had let it happen: a kingdom that cannot keep its own salt clean cannot govern.
3. THE KILLINGS OF THE FOREIGN DAUGHTERS. Noble daughters of other countries — guests on Aicruae soil — were raped and murdered in Aicruae. Guests. The word did most of the damage: every realm that had sent a daughter, for fosterage or marriage or schooling, heard it as its own near-miss, and the outcry abroad was not grief but indictment. Aicruae, they said, could not manage itself.

THE SENTENCE:

With foreign outcry as its warrant, the Crown stripped Aicruae of its kingdom title, reduced the realm to the Tanan Grand Duchy, and laid new taxes upon it. Framed as remedy — a mismanaged country taken in hand — and received in Aicruae as what it was: the granary punished for the rebellion, with the scandals as the clean gloves. Gherci, which fed nothing, threatened nothing, and blessed everything, kept its crown, and the lesson of the pairing was legible to every court on the continent: this is what loyalty keeps, and this is what defiance loses.

WHAT IT LEFT BEHIND:

A realm with no queen, a proud people under a lesser coronet, punitive taxes working like a slow grindstone, and somewhere, a deposed royal line — which is another way of saying: pretenders, grievance, and the long road that ends, eras later, in Lajazer.

[TBD] Dates for all three files and the sentence itself.

[TBD] Ahindo Yasavic — his motive and his fate. Deliberately left open; this is story fuel.

[TBD] In-world names for the salt poisoning and the killings — name-beat available (your canon names its wounds: the Massacre of Light, the Bloody Winter).

[TBD] Where the royal line went — abdication, exile, absorption into the Des, or the block.

THE MATSIALI KEY — the Era of Solis, from the founding (~7,214 BR) to 36 AR.

Through the empire's golden age these customs still ran patriarchal, as Aicruae always had, but with guardrails the later key would tear out. Sons were preferred, though daughters were not barred, and a woman could inherit, head a house, and rule. A man was honored for marrying

into a great house. A wife held named grounds to leave a marriage, not only to be dismissed from one. It was held improper to beat a wife or to strip her rank to shame her. Women were schooled and outspoken. None of it made the world hers; it made her a person within it, which is exactly what the next key denied. This is the true Era-of-Solis form, and it is the form the founding dynasty itself was raised in.

THE KESS ACROSS THE TWO KEYS

The kess was a patriarchal instrument in both eras, and it is worth being plain about that. A married woman wore her husband's station, then as later. When a woman married into a man's house her father-rank kess came off and her husband's count went on, and her rank moved with the man she was bound to. That much did not change when the keys changed. Two things did.

WHAT MATSIALI ALLOWED. A woman was not required to hold rank only through a man. A daughter who inherited a house, a woman who headed one, a queen who ruled in her own right, all these wore their own count, and no husband's station rose above it. A woman who held her own house did not take a husband's rank when he married into her; he took hers. So under this key a wristful of gold could be a woman's own, earned or inherited or ruled into, and not every high count on a woman's arm was the loan of some man. The door to her own standing was open, even if most women still walked through marriage rather than around it.

And rank was worn with the dignity the culture granted its women. A kess came off a wrist for true disgrace, a crime judged and named, not at a husband's temper. The same instinct that held it improper to beat a wife held it improper to strip her rank to shame her.

WHAT PATAOIUT CLOSED. Goteivati shut the door to a woman's own standing. With inheritance, headship, and the throne barred to women, no count on a woman's arm was hers rather than a man's, and every kess she wore was her father's grant or her husband's, nothing between. And the kess became a leash. Stripping with shears at displeasure, the borrowed gilt of the consort lane cut away before the court, the cold clause that let a man take back what he had lent, all of it is this key. What had marked rank came to mark ownership.

Era tags: the open door and the dignity are the Matsiali key (Era of Solis); the closed door and the leash are the Pataoiut key (36 AR, through Tanan and into Lajazer). The Nine-Count ladder and the consort lane's mechanics are already set down in the Nine-Count entry as the Pataoiut form; this is what stood in its place before.

FUNERAL CUSTOMS — WIDOWHOOD

(Both keys, with divergences marked)

THE WIDOW'S MARKS:

When a husband dies, his widow cuts her hair short and wears it bound, in a bun or updo, for as long as her widowhood lasts. In the middle of her forehead she is marked with the widow's red dot. These are the marks of loss in every era and every rank, from a fisherman's widow to a dowager queen, and they live on the head, not the arm: a widow keeps her kess, every one. Her standing survives her husband; only her hair and her brow say what she has buried. The dot belongs to the same marking-language as the High Mother's painted skin — rank and state written on the body in dye — and it comes off the day she remarries, when her hair may grow again.

THE DOWAGER'S NINE:

A dowager queen keeps her nine. The realm can hold two nines at once, the reigning queen's and the dowager's, and no one has ever confused them: one wrist belongs to a woman with long hair and a bare brow, the other to a woman with cropped hair, a bound crown, and the red dot. (Patch the Nine-Count ladder accordingly: "No other wrist in the kingdom may hold nine, save a dowager queen's, marked as a widow.")

MOURNING TERMS: under the Matsiali key, a year for a husband. Under Pataoiut, three.

REMARRIAGE — THE TWO KEYS:

Under Matsiali a widow past her mourning remarried without stain, and a widow of means — her chest intact, sometimes a threshold of her own — was courted, not pitied. Under Pataoiut remarriage stayed lawful and became a ruin: the second suit diminished (a lesser head, a private naming, no procession), her children remaining with the dead man's line, her name struck from his house's songs. The crown made a virtue of staying: a widow of rank who keeps the dot for twenty years may have it drawn again in gold by the crown's grace, and her household is relieved of levies for it — which is why, under this key, it is so often the household and not the widow who decides she will never love again. The coercion cuts both ways, and always did: kin who profit from her gold dot wall her in; kin who want her chest push her out the door.

THE HALF-CHEST LAW:

When a widow marries again, half her chest remains by law with her former family, as payment for her years under their roof — and the former family owes her a turnover-gift of equal

worth in answer, given as she goes, so that the parting is an exchange and not a seizure. Disputed worth goes before a magistrate. Under Matsiali the exchange was watched and mostly honest. Under Pataoiut the law survived with its teeth pulled: the dead man's kin control the valuation, the turnover-gift rots to a token, and a widow who presses the difference is pressing the family that keeps her children.

THE LIPEN:

The lipen of the dead marriage keeps its place above the hearth; death does not take down what was honestly hung. If the widow remarries, it comes down with honor and passes to the eldest child of that marriage, the proof of their line carried forward, and the new suitor's lipen takes the hearth. An annulled marriage is the one case where bone is broken: what never was may not hang.

[TBD] Funeral rites proper — burial, rites for the dead, mourning for parents and children — need the Religion doc's death-and-afterlife picture before building. This entry covers widowhood only.

[TBD] The widow's marks for a widower — does a man who buries a wife carry any mark at all? (Under Pataoiut, almost certainly not; under Matsiali, worth deciding.)

KINSHIP TERMS OF AICRUAE

(Both keys — the kin words are older than the key-split, and survive it unchanged)

All kin terms are invariant (one ruvo, many ruvo) and carry gender in the final vowel where paired: -o masculine, -a feminine.

Aro — father.

Dera — mother, and the wife of the house; every child of every mother addresses her so. At the knee she is Dey, the child's clip; grown children return to Dera.

Ama / Ame / Yena — the consort who bore you; every other consort; the concubines. (See: The Titles, under Family Structure, for the full weight these carry.)

Rin / Rina — brother / sister. Siblings are sorted compositionally by mother-word: a dera-rin is a brother by the wife, an ama-rin a brother by a consort. Under Pataoiut the distinction is a wall; under Matsiali, merely a fact.

Ori / Ora — son / daughter, as parents address them.

Olyen — uncle. The Olyen hold a formal office in marriage: they state the expected head and conduct the suits, for parents do not bargain over their own children.

Yen — aunt. The concubine's title Yena is this word bent into a name: the aunt-ed one, the mother demoted to aunt, the whole arrangement said politely.

Adera — for Grandmother

Oleyo — for grandfather

Der / Des — the wide kin: cousins and distant relations, with Des the royal family's own twist on it, as established.

Spouses hold no fixed address for one another; couples use endearments, which vary by pair, by class, and by mood, and say more than a fixed word would.

THE IMPERIAL INNER COURT

THE SHAPE ACROSS THE KEYS:

Under the Matsiali key the inner court is a bounded instrument. The crown keeps its full number and no more — the capped grades are ancient order, and the caps exist for a reason the whole court understands: they curb factional strife by limiting what there is to fight over. Every woman who enters the imperial household enters through the High Mother's approval, and her leave is law, not courtesy. The court is also the empire's mixing chamber: six realms' daughters under one roof, and this is the floor the Cascade first walked across, the kess grammar leaving on their wrists.

Under Pataoiut the same rooms swell. The caps hold at the top and the bottom comes open, crowds of entrants beneath the graded ranks, exactly as the consort lane describes. The Empress's leave rots to theater, the grades-and-gilt machinery becomes the architecture of the place, and the court gains its terrible pressure valve: with daughters barred from the throne, a sonless Emperor's crown drifts toward brothers and nephews — unless the Empress opens her once-only door and adopts a consort's son. In the later empire there is no more contested object than that adoption.

THE INTAKE — THREE LAYERS:

The spine is the Showing: every third year, the ranked houses present their daughters of age at court. Under Matsiali, presentation is prestige — houses bring daughters who wish to be brought, and selection is elevation. Pataoiut keeps the ceremony and adds the teeth: presentation becomes compulsory for the ranked houses, and no presented daughter may wed until the crown has seen the lists. The crown's first look, made law.

Over the Showing lie the treaty-daughters — women owed to the court by the realms as

diplomacy, and, when the wind turns, as polite hostages. The court's composition is a living map of imperial favor: a realm in grace sends few and places them high; a realm under suspicion sends more and watches them vanish into the middle ranks. And beneath both, the open ladder: ambitious houses volunteering daughters into the lower tiers, because proximity is its own currency.

After the fall to Tanan, the duchy's daughters still stand in the Showing, and no one at court is ever certain whether they have come as climbers, hostages, or spies. All three, usually.

THE GHERCI EXCEPTION:

Gherci bans polygamy at home, by law, to ration its scarce men fairly — and yet Ghercin daughters serve in the consort corps. The square is the Teire's: imperial service is sanctified as something other than marriage, the daughter given to the crown as one is given to the temple, a consecration rather than a wedding. The church blesses at the summit what it bans in the parish, and every Ghercin consort lives inside that doctrine — lawful at court, unthinkable at home, holy on paper.

THE EXIT:

Under Matsiali the court has a door out. A consort who has borne no children is released with honor after nine years' service, provisioned from the crown's purse, free to wed — and released imperial consorts are prized matches, carrying court polish, court connections, and court fashion into every province that receives one. The Cascade rode home in their trunks. A consort who has borne the crown's children stays, bound by blood now, not tenure.

Under Pataoiut there is no term and no door. Entry is forever, and the only exits are the ones already written: the shears, the casting aside, and the grave.

[TBD] The Teire doctrine's name — the consecration that makes a Ghercin consort lawful.

[TBD] The four other realms' consorts — their clash-texture waits on Coelum, Pireaynea, Equateiy, and Vikitsv receiving marriage-culture entries of their own.

FAMILY STRUCTURE — THE MATSIALI FORM

WHERE A WIFE BELONGS:

Under Matsiali, marriage added a house to a woman; it did not subtract one. A wife remained a daughter of her natal house for life — its name still partly hers, its roof still open to her, its men still holding standing to walk through her husband's gate and ask hard questions if she was wronged. She belonged to two houses, and both would bleed for her. This is the quiet foundation under everything else she held: her chest was untouchable because it was natal wealth in her hands, not a gift his family had absorbed; her two lists had muscle because an entire second house stood behind them; and the half-chest law's "payment for her time under their roof" was ordinary accounting between houses that both still claimed her.

Pataoiut's first cut was here. Sever the natal tie and a wife passes into her husband's house whole — but as a permanent outsider, never quite blood where she lives and no longer her birth family's business. Every downstream cruelty follows from that one severance: a

wife charged with theft for spending in her own home, because the home was never legally hers; a Wall that must specify "no natal roof to return to," because her birth house had become her only backup and the law had to name the woman who'd lost it.

THE INTERIOR:

The wife ruled the interior in both keys; that structure is ancient. The Matsiali difference is that her rule had recourse past her husband. He headed the house and judged its disputes, but his judgment was not final — a wife wronged had her counts, her kin, and the magistrate beyond him, so his arbitration answered to something. And her leave on consorts was real, as set down in the consort entry: taken past her word, it was her ground to walk. Above them both stood the Adera, holding under this key what she held openly and by right — the house's elder sovereign, no filial workaround required. Pataoiut did not dethrone her; it just rerouted her power through her son's duty and called it order.

THE LINE:

The wall is ancient and identical in both keys: the line belongs to the wife's children, by her body or her formal adoption, and to no one else. A father's word buys a consort's child comfort — tutors, placement, a knighthood, gifts from his purse — and never blood. What differed between the eras was not the law but the need. Under Matsiali, a house of daughters simply passed to its eldest girl, so the wife's adoption door stood mostly unused, a pragmatic instrument for the rare house with no children of hers at all. It took the daughter-ban of 36 AR to turn that same unchanged door into the desperate passage of the later era. The golden age was no utopia for a consort's child; the outside was always the outside. It was merely quieter then, because fewer people were clawing at the door.

THE TITLES:

Dera, Ama, Ame, Yena — the words are older than either key. What shifted was their weight. Under Matsiali the Dera's authority was law with teeth, the Ama's warmth was a bounded but dignified place, and the lower tiers ran thin: rank caps and a wife's real leave kept households small, so the sprawling harems of the later era, with their crowds of Ame and Yena, are a Pataoiut inflation, not an old custom.

CHILDREN:

Daughters were schooled beside sons — letters, numbers, the songs, the law — as Matsiali schooled women everywhere. The decree of 36 AR cut the daughters' lessons off mid-generation, and the first Pataoiut generation of great ladies was the last to have been taught by right rather than by a father's quiet defiance.

THE ILEN: see Marrying In (The Matsiali Form). His honored place is that entry's whole subject; here it is enough to say his children belonged to his wife's line, and no one thought it strange.

Era tags: this entire entry is the Matsiali key (Era of Solis); its counterpart is the Family Structure entry already set down, which is the Pataoiut key (36 AR, through Tanan and into Lajazer).

HAIR — THE SOUL, THE GIFT, AND THE LINE
(Both keys, with the divergence marked)

THE DOCTRINE:

Hair is the reflection of the soul, and a gift from the gods. It is received through your parents and grows from your blood — the living thread of your lineage, worn openly on the body. All three truths are taught as one: the gods gave it, the soul shows in it, the line carries it. To damage it lightly insults the line. To cut it deliberately is to give up a piece of yourself — of soul and lineage both — which is precisely what makes the widow's offering an offering, and not a haircut.

THE FIRST BINDING:

Children wear their hair loose; that is what childhood looks like. At coming of age the hair is bound up for the first time, before witnesses, and worn bound in public ever after — the binding is adulthood, put on in a morning. For a daughter, the first binding and the first kess land on the same day: bound and braceleted, a woman. The custom also keeps the widow legible: every adult wears the bun, but only she wears it cropped beneath, with the dot above.

CARE, STYLE, AND OATHS:

Bound and covered hair is protected hair; the care is the reverence. Among the Taili majority, styles and braid-patterns carry region and house — a grammar of plaits that a sharp eye reads like a badge. And the gravest promises are sworn on the hair: an oath taken with a hand to the head, and a lock forfeited, cut and surrendered, by the one who breaks it. A person missing a lock is a person the district watches.

THE SHEARS OF THE LAW:

Because the thing is holy, taking it is a sentence. The Code of Esa punishes sacrilege and

treason with forced shaving before the public — the profaning of the gods and the betrayal of crown or house, which the doctrine holds to be one offense at two altitudes, for the crown sits inside the sacred order the gods built. The gods' gift stripped, the soul's mirror confiscated. And the punishment keeps its own calendar — a shaved head is a walking sentence, and everyone can read how recently you were judged by how far it has grown back. No fine humiliates longer.

THE TWO KEYS:

Matsiali held the hair-duties over everyone, men and women alike, down to the widower's shears and the flat red line. Pataoiut kept the women's law whole and quietly released the men from theirs — the widower's exemption is only the visible case of a general amnesty. Under the later key, no man owes the gods or the line anything of himself, and every sacred duty that remains is a duty that lands on a woman.

[TBD] The priesthood's hair — how the Danepelie and temple clergy wear theirs; check the Religion doc before setting it.

[TBD] The braid-grammar of the Taili — expandable into its own entry if wanted.

ORIGINS OF THE THREE SUB-RELIGIONS — THE FIRST CONCORD

The Question the Twins Left Behind

Aryanara and Vekta built the Circle's theology and died without prescribing its worship. Aryanara's writings gave the faith its cosmology: the Song, the

cycle of souls, corruption as the only true ending. Vekta's teaching gave it a discipline of living. Neither sister ever set down what form of worship the pantheon required of the faithful. While they lived, their presence was answer enough.

The second sister died around 14,200 BR, and the Circle, not yet a century old, had no head, no council, and no saint to consult — the age of the Circle's founding falls entirely inside the long gap between Galamma's death and Dorthargel's birth, and no saint walked in those years to carry a verdict down. What the Circle had was a doctrine that forced the question. The faith taught, and the fate of the Gods of Old had proven, that worship sustains divinity. If worship is a feeding, then a feeding is owed. The twins' students split three ways over what the gods are owed.

The Three Answers

****Leneyez****, sharpest of the students at Aryanara's eastern seat, argued her teacher's doctrine to its coldest end. Faith concentrates where a life ends. What is offered wholly, feeds wholly. Blood, she taught, is the one worship the gods cannot mistake for habit. The lords of the lowlands took up her rite within a generation, and not for love of theology: a faith in which judgment is a feeding makes a lord's power sacred, and his executions holy.

****Rillic****, who studied at both seats and refused to the end of his life to choose between the sisters, answered that the offering is attention.

Mortals were set on the earth to fuel the gods' strength and hold them tethered to the mortal world, and a tether must be gripped, hour after hour, or it frays. His rite fixed prayer at five appointed hours of the day, each held long enough to cost the one praying something real. Worship that costs nothing, he taught, feeds nothing.

****Barqeten****, who kept Vekta's northern seat after her death, taught that the Song does not ask to be fed. It asks to be lived. A body kept well is a standing offering; a life in harmony worships with every breath it draws. Her school held both other answers to be confessions of doubt — as if the Song that made the world could hunger.

The three rites still carry their first teachers' names.

The Contention (c. 14,200–14,171 BR)

For a generation the schools contended, first in letters, then in pulpits, then in the streets. The lowlands saw prayer-houses of the hours burned at dawn devotion with the faithful still inside, the killers saying the silence would feed the gods better. In the river towns, a blood-priest was held under in his own offering basin until he stopped moving. Congregations unchurched one another. Villages split down their middles. Through all of it the gods sent no sign, though all three schools begged for one.

The First Concord (14,171 BR)

The schools met at Aryanara's teaching-seat in the eastern heartland, one century to the year after the founding — a symmetry so tidy that some chroniclers suspect the scribes moved the date to make it so. The Concord was signed out of exhaustion. Every school was bleeding, none could destroy the other two, and the lords behind Leneyez had discovered that holy war is expensive. Its terms:

- **The Three Recognitions.** Each rite is a true feeding of the pantheon. No rite may unchurch another; no priest may bar a Circle believer from a holy place for keeping a different rite.
- **The Pekna belongs to the god, not the rite.** Every temple is raised to a deity, and any of the three rites may be kept within it according to the custom of the place.
- **Blood is bound.** The Leneyez rite continues under fixed terms — what may be offered, when, and by whose hand. (The terms of blood are given under LENEYEZ.)
- **Assembly, not blade.** Disputes between the rites are settled by concord assembled, never by arms. The Concord thereby made itself a standing institution; later gatherings are numbered from this one.

It was sealed with the formula later fixed in the Zyrazithia: *"
The Song is one. The voices are three."*

What the Concord Bought, and What It Cost

The Concord bought seven thousand years of official harmony, and it bought it with a contract, not a communion. Each rite privately holds the others insufficient. Leneyez priests call the hours "begging." Rillic priests call the blood-rite "butchery with hymns." Barqeten's faithful pity them both as children who think their mother must be fed by hand. The contempt surfaces where it always does, in marriage: seven millennia after the Concord, House Liazen's Rillic devotion was still reason enough to fight Queen Isalian's marriage into Leneyez House Patton.

The official histories of the Circle teach that its first century was harmonious and the Concord a triumph of unity. The fragments that survive from the contention — a burned prayer-house's roll of the dead, a letter begging a cousin to flee the river towns — say otherwise. The Circle smoothed its own beginnings the way it smooths everything.

Later theologians noticed what the contention proved and were careful about saying it aloud: the gods let their faithful burn one another's houses for thirty years rather than name a preferred worship, and the pantheon has been sustained across three sub-denominations ever since. Three feedings are safer than one. A god fed three ways can never be starved by one change of heart. The gods have never confirmed this reading. They never do.

*(Note for the Pataoiut era, 36 AR onward: imperial priests, uneasy that the blood-rite bears a woman's name, taught that Leneyez was a man. The

older texts they failed to burn say otherwise.)*

LENEYEZ — THE TERMS OF BLOOD

The third clause of the First Concord bound the blood-rite in a graded code, formally the Terms of Blood, known everywhere as the Ladder. The Ladder did not soften Leneyez. It organized it, and what is organized survives. Two of its clauses are still quoted seven thousand years on: *"Let each feed the god from his own table,"* and *"No hand shall take the unwilling free."*

The Beast Tier — The Monthly Rite

The month is fed by beasts, graded to the household's means. The poor owe fowl. The freeholder owes a goat or ewe. The lord owes a bull. Offering beneath one's means is impiety under the Terms, for a thin offering from a fat table tells the god what he is worth to you — and so piety in Leneyez lands is legible wealth. Every Pekna keeps blood-rolls recording what each household brought, and the rolls are consulted for marriages, appointments, and suits at law. A family's standing can be read in what it bleeds.

The Festival Tier — Human Blood

Human offering belongs to the high occasions only: the great feasts of the year, the consecration of a new Pekna, a coronation, the eve of war, and calamity — drought, plague, defeat — when the god's strength must be restored at cost. The Terms fix the order of resort:

- **The condemned, first.** In Leneyez lands the execution is the offering; the headsman's block and the basin are one institution. Courts sit to the liturgical calendar, and every commoner knows the proverb: *never stand trial in a feast-week.* The record bears the proverb out — condemnations rise as the feasts approach, and no court has ever admitted why.
- **The bought, second.** When the courts run dry, the temple buys. A debtor may be sold to the basin by his creditor, or sell himself, the basin-price paid to his kin. The Terms grant one mercy, and it is precise: the bought may be redeemed at any hour before the feast's eve, if the debt is met. Families have beggared three generations raising a redemption by the eve. Some raise it a day late.
- **The willing, last and highest.** The rarest offering is the free soul who chooses the basin — the old warrior, the dying matriarch, the penitent. Doctrine names this the summit of the Ladder, the costliest feeding the law permits, and reserves it for the summit occasions: coronation and calamity. The willing one's family is blessed, paid, and ennobled in the blood-rolls for three generations.

The offered must be whole and hale, for a broken offering insults the god it feeds. The Terms made this a screening; the desperate made it a door. Jailers in Leneyez lands know the price of a quiet maiming that renders a condemned man unfit for the basin and fit only for the rope, and families pay it, because of the two deaths, they fear the basin more — or say they do. Leneyez doctrine teaches the opposite: that the offered soul is carried, favored in its next turning of the cycle. The teaching is what lets mothers watch. Whether it is true, the gods have never said.

The Rite Itself

Only a consecrated Blood-priest of the receiving god may open the vein, and only at that god's basin, before the god's image, at the appointed hour. The blood is the feeding; it is given whole to the basin. The body is burned the same night and the ash given to the fields. *The god keeps the blood. The land keeps the rest.* The old Rillic slander that Leneyez priests eat of the offering has never had a witness in seven thousand years, and has never once needed one to spread.

What the Terms Protect, and Whom

The clause the voice school carried out of the Concord as its victory — no hand shall take the unwilling free — is the most praised sentence in the Terms and the most carefully made. Slaves are not free. Debtors are not free. The condemned are not free. The clause has held for seven

millennia precisely because it protects everyone who could afford to be angry, and no one who couldn't. Justice in Leneyez lands is not corrupted by the basin. It is calibrated to it.

(Forward note, Pataoiut era: a code that grades offerings can be regraded. When Goteivati III's priests turned the rite toward emperor and ancestors in 36 AR, they did not break the Ladder. They added a rung above the gods.)